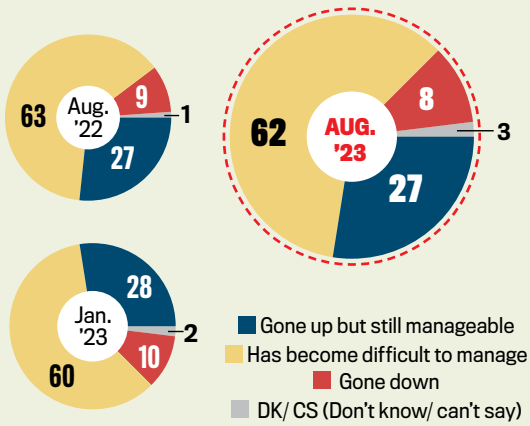
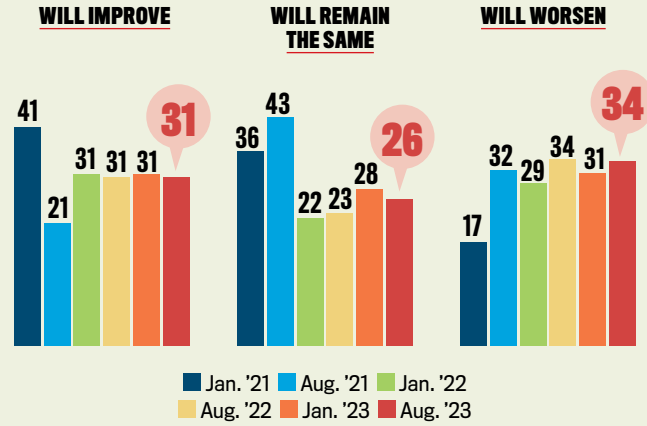


Q. How would you compare your current daily expenses with last year's?



For a large majority, penny-pinching has become a way of life

Q. How do you see the Indian economy in the next six months?



A third of the people feel it will all go downhill by 2024

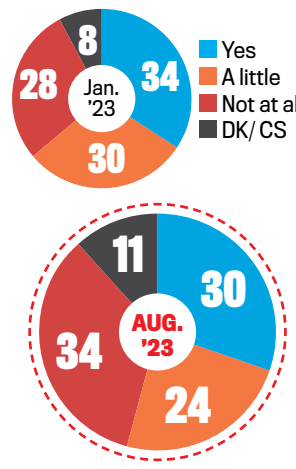
All figures in % and rounded off

demand. Overall, consumption demand has been lagging, which prevents private entrepreneurs from investing more in new factories, equipment or offices. In fact, India's industrial output growth slumped to a three-month low of 3.7 per cent in June from 5.3 per cent in May, dragged under by sluggish expansion in manufacturing.

BURNING PRICES

The biggest bane for the Modi government in the post-Covid years has been the runaway inflation. The pandemic had led to a spike in the prices of food and fuel worldwide. And while India has remained more or less insulated from global vagaries due to its focus on its burgeoning domestic market compared to exports, the Centre's efforts to rein in fuel prices leave much to be desired. Crude oil prices have cooled off from their pandemic highs globally,

Q. Has the Modi government been able to generate employment?



All figures in percentage

A slim majority may feel the job market has grown but, overall, disillusionment rises

but the prices of petrol and diesel continue to be high. Petrol prices are still more than Rs 100 a litre in several Indian cities. At the same time, high food prices have driven inflation beyond the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) targeted range (2-6 per cent) to 7.4 per cent in July. To curb inflation, the RBI has held on to interest rates. For the third consecutive time, it kept the repo rate—the rate at which Indian commercial banks borrow from the central bank—at 6.5 per cent (the last increase, by 25 basis points, was in February 2023). The central bank is likely to maintain this 'hawkish' stance and desist from cutting interest rates for the rest of this financial year. That will mean a long wait for consumers looking for lower interest rates on home loans and other retail loans to make their purchases.

Tomatoes have been the chief 'villain' in food inflation, their cost